90-DAY SOFTWARE TESTING CAREER ROADMAP

Smoke Testing Checklist

A fast confidence check that a build is stable enough to test further.

Introduction

Smoke testing is a quick check of the most critical paths to confirm a new build is stable enough to justify deeper testing. If smoke fails, you stop and send the build back rather than wasting time.

Instructions

- Run on every new build before detailed testing.
- Cover only the most critical, must-work paths.
- Keep it fast — minutes, not hours.
- If it fails, reject the build and report immediately.

Real QA Example

For an e-commerce site, a smoke test confirms: the site loads, a user can log in, search returns results, an item can be added to the cart, and checkout opens. If any fail, the build is not ready for full testing.

Smoke Checklist

- Application loads without errors
- User can log in and log out
- Primary navigation works
- Core create/read action works (e.g. search, view item)
- Key transaction starts (e.g. add to cart / begin checkout)
- No blocking console/server errors
- Result recorded; build accepted or rejected

Best Practice Tips

- Automate the smoke suite so it runs on every deploy.
- Keep it short and stable — it is a gate, not full coverage.
- Agree what "must pass" means with the team.

Common Mistakes

- Turning smoke testing into a full regression pass.
- Skipping it and discovering the build is broken hours later.
- No clear accept/reject decision at the end.

> **INSIDE STLC PRO TIP**
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> Smoke first, deep testing second. Catching a dead build in five minutes saves a wasted afternoon.